

WISDOM OF THE ORIENT SERIES #25

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"Wise men subscribe  
when the time is ripe.  
The unwise keep  
waiting for a better offer  
that may never come"

BRIE T'U CHIEK, PHILOSOPHER

A public interest message issued by **digit**



The AVM FRITZ! Mini is the ultimate wireless device. Built around Wi-Fi, it allows you to make VoIP calls to both landlines and personal computers, streams music and podcasts, and displays call information, e-mails, and RSS news

out first before subscribing. Also note that some ISPs charge by data traffic, instead of a flat monthly or quarterly rate. For such a service, you are likely to be billed for a voice call, since a voice communication over the Internet essentially involves exchange of data packets

## Dialling Into VoIP

The minimum requirements for making phone calls over the Internet are: a PC at one or both ends, VoIP-enabling software running on the computer(s), a microphone, and speakers or headset. You then install the software at every computer that you need to connect to, and go through the sign-up process for the software. Placing a PC-to-PC call is as simple as double-clicking on a contact's ID in the software; dialling to an outstation phone line will require you to dial the phone number.

Apart from this simple solution involving your computer, you can also pick up a VoIP-enabled handset to make calls. Such handsets resemble traditional phones, and generally connect to the Internet via Wi-Fi, or even through cable. A handset will support a particular software implementation: for example, Skype is widely supported by such solutions. The handset then effectively replaces your computer/speaker/microphone combination. Moreover, if the handset uses Wi-Fi to connect to the Internet, its usage area is only limited by the Wi-Fi coverage in your company or location.

Some handsets also allow traditional GSM calls to be made; you can switch to VoIP when you are under Wi-Fi coverage, and fall back to the cellular network when outside the coverage area, making for a comprehensive and cheap communication solution.

## Talk Isn't Free

When it comes to call charges, most ISPs or software solutions provide free computer-to-computer calls. They, however, charge a per-minute rate for PC to phone calls; this rate varies with the ISP and the software, and it also depends on what country you wish to connect with. Even so, a phone call made over the Internet is significantly cheaper than one made over a traditional phone line or using a cell phone.

Whether you're making a PC-to-PC or a PC-to-phone call, you will need the appropriate software. This can either be generic IM software such as MSN Messenger, Yahoo! Messenger or Google Talk, or it can be software specifically designed for VoIP calls such as Skype, Zoep, or JahJah.

Apart from cost, an important benefit of VoIP is that as long as you have a connection to the Internet, you can field a call. An incoming call, for example, is automatically routed to a VoIP-enabled phone, irrespective of where you are.

With a sufficiently fast Net connection, this can be of great benefit to a business. Since you are essentially transferring packets over the Net, a VoIP connection can be quite data rich: you can hold a video conversation, for example, exchange documents over an open line, seamlessly invite other parties to a conference call, access address books, and be aware of the online status of colleagues. Of course, the availability of such services depends upon the software used to dial in or out. ■

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